



BEFORE

Scarred by World War I, Britain and France sought to avoid war with Nazi Germany but were thwarted by Hitler's ambitions.

MUNICH PACT

The Munich Pact was agreed between Britain, Germany, Italy, and France in 1938. It ordered the surrender of German-speaking areas of Czechoslovakia to Germany. Anglo-French **appeasement** of Hitler's wishes is criticized, but in 1938 neither nation could challenge Germany.

HITLER'S QUEST FOR *LEBENSRAUM*

The need for *Lebensraum*, or "living space," informed Hitler's plans for war. He believed that

for the "superior" **Aryan race** <<386–87 to dominate, Germany needed more land. He targeted neighboring territories with ethnic German populations. In 1938 Hitler entered Austria. *Anschluss* (the union with Austria) was followed by occupation of the Czech provinces, Bohemia and Moravia, in violation of the Munich Pact.



ANSCHLUSS

The Blitz

After defeat in the Battle of Britain (see right), Hitler launched 57 consecutive nightly bombing attacks on London, known as the Blitz. In this image, a German Heinkel 111 bomber flies over the Thames River in London during a bombing raid.



Blitzkrieg

On September 1, 1939, Nazi Germany invaded neighboring Poland. France and Britain declared war two days later. Well-equipped German forces then pushed into Scandinavia and the Netherlands, crushing all opposition. Within a year, a seemingly invincible German army had conquered vast tracts of Europe.

Germany's assault on Poland began with the airforce (*Luftwaffe*) blanket-bombing roads, railroads, towns, and villages, sending terrified local populations fleeing ahead of the German advance. The chaos of refugees on the roads disrupted Polish counterattacks, and the German land invasion swept across the country at astonishing speed. This was *blitzkrieg*. The response of the British and French (the Allies) to German progress was hesitant. In the next two weeks, they did little more than survey the situation, while the German armed forces, or *Wehrmacht*, soon had the Polish capital, Warsaw,

surrounded. Poland capitulated when the Soviet Union, which had made a pact of nonaggression with Hitler, invaded from the east. There then followed several months of little military action, known as the "Phony War," in which the Allies built up weapon stocks and dropped leaflets to persuade the German people of the evils of their Nazi leaders.

On April 9, 1940, Hitler invaded Denmark and Norway in a preemptive strike against the British, who had threatened to occupy Scandinavia. The Phony War was over. On May 10, Hitler pushed westward toward France, conquering the Netherlands,

Belgium, and Luxembourg in just two days, to arrive at the French border. Both British and French commanders believed that the *Wehrmacht* would be held at the Maginot Line, fortifications

BLITZKRIEG The tactic used by the German army to invade Poland. Meaning "lightning war," it involved swift, intense attacks that aimed to destroy the enemy quickly. It often included bombing raids.

constructed along the German border, and by the Belgian forests of the Ardennes, which they considered impassable for tanks. However, the Nazis swiftly broke through and



Pushing the war effort

This poster was issued by the British Ministry of Home Security to encourage citizens to join the Fire Guard. Fire Guards, known as "the Midnight Watch," were volunteer patrols who extinguished fires after German air raids. The poster's tone is typical of the propaganda produced by the wartime government to promote the war effort.